



Letters & Notices



If we want to retain our veterinary graduates we should start by allowing our nurses to give vaccinations

ANIMAL WELFARE

The future of keeping pet reptiles and amphibians

WE note with interest the review 'Future of keeping pet reptiles and amphibians: towards integrating animal welfare, human health and environmental sustainability' (VR, 28 October, 2017, vol 181, p 450), and the associated viewpoint from Warwick *et al* (VR, 28 October 2017, vol 181, pp 454-455). We would like to make some additional comments in order to advance the debate.

In our opinion, Pasmans *et al* fail to make any specific case for the benefits of keeping reptiles and amphibians; instead falling into the logical fallacy that because there are

some benefits to people from keeping companion animals, keeping reptiles and amphibians as companion animals necessarily brings benefits. Moreover, even if there are benefits to people, the authors fail to demonstrate that the damage to animal welfare, animal health and wildlife protection associated with the trade in, and keeping of, these animals is significantly outweighed by any benefits to people. Simply listing the pros and cons — without consideration of the relative significance of each — presents an unrealistic and overly simplistic assessment of a highly complex issue.

The authors of the review claim that an easily accessible, extensive and ever-increasing body of literature is available with regard to husbandry of most species kept as pets. However, research on what constitutes optimal nutrition, environment health, and behavioural requirements is in its infancy — or absent — for the vast majority of reptiles and amphibians. Our research shows that husbandry recommendations and advice for commonly kept reptile species available online currently not only lack scientific validation but also vary dramatically in content and criteria. The paucity of reports of poor treatment or cruelty in trade and keeping is likely due to a lack of reporting which cannot be taken as an indication that animal suffering through the trade is low.

We feel the authors failed to conduct even a rudimentary analysis of the impacts of international trade in live animals for the exotic pet market, which is known to be extraordinarily damaging to many reptiles and amphibians at an individual and species level. An assessment of 45 per cent of known reptile species identified at least 1390 species are threatened by 'biological resource use', 355 of these species are intentionally targeted by collectors.¹ Given that the trade in only 8 per cent

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of known reptile species is governed by international trade regulations, a precautionary approach to the trade in species for the domestic pet market is clearly justified. In their analysis of the global trade in exotic pets 2006-2012, Bush *et al* describe the exotic pet trade as an 'important and increasing driver of biodiversity loss' which 'compromises the standards required for good animal welfare'.² Other authors have examined the 'anthropogenic allee effect', concluding that the increased value people place on rarity could be a driver of extinction for some species in trade.³

An ethical framework should be applied to the discussion on the trade in, and keeping of, reptiles and amphibians, in keeping with the BVA's animal welfare strategy from 2016.⁴ We strongly advocate the application of a highly precautionary approach, particularly given the well-known lack of husbandry standards, expert veterinary availability or enforcement resources, and the acknowledged high level of illegal trade and lack of evidence for its sustainability or safety. In many respects, the paper provides the evidence for the adoption of a highly precautionary approach through its examination (albeit superficial) of the various disadvantages of exotic pet keeping to human health and safety, animal health and welfare, conservation and ecological health. We would propose a ban on the trade in, and keeping of, animals unless and until it can be shown to be sustainable, capable of fully providing for animals' needs, and free of human, animal or ecological health risks.

Chris Draper, Mark Jones, Born Free Foundation, Broadlands Business Campus, Langhurstwood Road, Horsham, West Sussex RH12 4QP
e-mail: markj@bornfree.org.uk

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The future of keeping pet reptiles and amphibians

Chris Draper and Mark Jones

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